



6 Types of Student Housing Options for College Students

By [College Raptor Staff](#) | Last updated on October 29, 2025

Key Takeaways

- Whether you are a freshman or senior in college, student housing comes in many different options—both on-campus and off-campus.
- On-campus living usually provides a sense of community and convenience for freshmen and sophomores. You can choose from a few different college dorm layouts, apartment-style housing, or even Greek life.
- Off-campus living allows for more freedom and independence—whether you rent an apartment with your best friends, a house with a big backyard for hangouts, or move back in with your parents.

On-Campus vs Off-Campus Types of Student Housing

Entering college as a freshman often brings up a lot of thoughts concerning dorm rooms—how to decorate, whether such a small space will really feel like home, and how to make the most of the closet space and tiny beds. While most freshmen spend their first year in dorms, many wonder about their living arrangements for sophomore year. If you loved your dorm experience you might just sign up for it again, but if you're craving a change, there are plenty of other living arrangements to consider.

One of the most exciting things about going to college is getting to live independently with new friends (and [roommates](#)), but not knowing your student housing situation can be nerve-wracking. This is why we are breaking down some of the most common types of student housing for college students.



On-Campus Housing

When it comes to student housing on campus, you might picture something you've seen in a movie—a small room with two twin beds, two desks, a mini fridge, and the communal bathroom at the end of the hall. While that traditional setup is common, it's far from the only option available. You'll also encounter different style dorms, apartment-style living, and Greek housing:

1. College Dorms

Dorms often take center stage in the conversation about college living. In fact, many colleges require first-year students to live in the dorms to build a sense of community. They're a great way to make new friends and oftentimes floors will even organize events to bring residents together. Though you can most likely expect a smaller living area, dorm buildings do come with perks, including Wi-fi throughout, laundry facilities, and on-call maintenance. Let's look at a couple of dorm setups:

Singles & Doubles With Shared Bathroom

In general, these dorms are equipped with one or two XL twin beds (which can often be lofted), a dresser, a chair and desk, closet space, and a mini fridge. Residents all share a bathroom located on their floor. While this is a typical design, room features depend on each college and you can typically find detailed information on the college's website.

Here's an example of a classic college dorm room:





University of Florida | Double, Graham Hall

Singles & Doubles/Multi Roommate With Ensuite

“Ensuite” is a fancy term for having your own bathroom or one that you share with only roommates. This dorm style can be found as a two-person, four-person, or six-person suite. Here’s an example of what that might look like:



University of Miami | Double Suite, Pearson Residential College

2. Apartment Style

While the previously discussed dorm styles with no kitchen or living room space are typically for underclassmen, on-campus college apartments are usually prioritized for upperclassmen. Apartment-style housing is essentially what it sounds like—an apartment, but it’s on campus and operated by the college. In these spaces, you can usually find single or double rooms with a shared bathroom, a kitchen complete with a stove, oven, and fridge, and a furnished common living area. Just like in dorm rooms, college apartments often feature an XL twin bed, dresser, desk, and chair.

Here’s an example of an on-campus apartment:



Kosove Apartments
2-4 Room Apartments

Designed by Christopher Herrera '18

University of South Florida | Double Bedroom 4 Person Apartment, Kosove Apartments



Cypress Apartments
4 Person Apartments

Designed by Christopher Herrera '18

University of South Florida | Single Bedroom 4 Person Apartment, Cypress Apartments

Note that when you're in an on-campus apartment, many colleges still offer dining options and meal plans, though they may not be mandatory. If you prefer not to have a meal plan, take into account the proximity of the nearest grocery stores and how you'll get there. If you or your roommates lack a car and the grocery store isn't conveniently located near public transportation or within walking/biking distance, you might want to reconsider opting for a meal plan.

3. Sorority and Fraternity Housing

If you decide to go Greek, you might find yourself living in a historic frat or sorority house with your fellow brothers and sisters. This typically lends itself to more space, yet still maintains a sense of community. These houses differ from campus to campus, as do the chapters themselves. As with any form of housing, there are fees to pay every semester. In some houses, the average fees may depend on the sorority or fraternity themselves, whether or not there are meals provided, and if any additional amenities are offered. If you're [interested in Greek life](#), make sure you do plenty of research before joining!



Flickr user bluephi.net

Off-Campus Housing



about on-campus versus off-campus housing options and where students typically prefer to live.

Off-campus housing has its benefits—like more privacy, the chance to create your own space, and the ability to choose your roommates—but of course, it also means there are leases to sign, utilities to pay, and roomie rent money to keep track of. But for many, independence is well worth the additional tasks. Here are a few off-campus options you have:

4. Apartments

Unlike on-campus apartments, which must follow campus rules and regulations, off-campus apartments offer more freedom and flexibility. Imagine living with your best friends, decorating your space with your own furniture and personal touches, and throwing the occasional movie night or dinner party! Some apartments even market themselves to be great for student living, especially in college towns.

5. Houses

There may be houses for rent surrounding or near college campuses. This is typically found around campuses that aren't located in a highly populated city. Campuses in suburban towns may have houses for rent which is a fun way to live with roommates and have your own space. You may even find a house with a great backyard for fun hangouts with friends.

6. Living at Home

If you're on a tight [budget](#) and you live close to home, moving back in with your parents might just be the ultimate money-saving hack. Not only will you save on rent costs, but you'll also save on furniture and dorm-room essentials. Of course, your parents might ask you to do some extra chores around the house, or have you be responsible for your own laundry, but it's a valid option all the same. And hey, at least being at home you know the rules and you probably get your own room!

If you're thinking about living off campus at some point, make sure to look into the safety of the surrounding area and see if your college has resources for nearby apartments or houses. After all, you're still in school, so you want to make sure you can zip back to campus and stay connected to all the on-campus fun and activities.

Take a look at each college's website to see what type of housing options are available to you. Housing types and layouts vary from college to college. Above are some common types that may be seen frequently for on-campus and off-campus options.

When it comes to college living—you have options! [Housing types and layouts vary from college to college](#), so make sure you take a look at each college's website to see what type of housing options are available to you. At the



Match Tool!

By College Raptor Staff

Applying to college can be challenging, and so we at College Raptor feel it's our duty to make that process as easy, smooth, and rewarding as possible. We work hard to clarify dense material, dispel myths, uncover information, and help you learn what you need to know!

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